

Test Layer 4: Unified Action Point System

Version: 2026-04-25 framework. To be finalised after Layers 1–3 are tested.

Framework — to be finalised after Layers 1–3 are tested. Incorporates whichever Layer 1–3 changes were accepted. Sections marked [FROM LAYER X] indicate where those results plug in.

What we're testing: Does collapsing two turn phases into a single Action Point pool create better decisions and reduce cognitive overhead?

Hypothesis: When moving and casting draw from the same resource (AP), every action involves an opportunity cost trade-off. This creates more “agonising choices” and makes spells feel more central — they compete directly with movement rather than living in a separate phase.

Watch for:

- Do turns feel more fluid (one decision space) or more overwhelming (too many options)?
- Do players spread AP across pieces or focus on one?
- Does anyone rush a piece across the board using all 3 AP for movement?
- Are “pure caster” turns (0 movement, 3 skills) viable and interesting?
- Is 3 AP the right number?

Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

Draw conditions:

- No piece has been captured for 10 consecutive full rounds.
- Only the two Kings remain on the board.

Components

- **Board:** [FROM LAYER results — likely 10×10, no terrain.]
- **Per player:** [Current piece count — likely 5 Champions + 6 Guards + 1 King unless changed.]
- **Shared:** Skill tokens/cards, Rune tokens, Round tracker.

Setup

[Same as current after Layer 1–3 results.]

CHANGED: Turn Structure — Unified Action Points

Old system (two phases):

1. Movement Phase: 2 Move Slots
2. Action Phase: N Skill Slots

New system (unified):

Each turn you receive **3 Action Points (AP)**. You may spend each AP on one of:

- **Move:** Move one piece (by its speed).
- **Skill:** Activate one equipped skill on a Champion or King (pay Rune cost).
- **Attack:** Perform a Standard Attack (move onto enemy tile, deal 1 DMG).

You may use 0, 1, 2, or 3 AP. Unused AP are lost — no banking.

The concept of Skill Slots is removed. Each skill activation costs 1 AP + its Rune cost. The former Skill Slot progression (was +1 every 10 rounds) is replaced by the flat 3 AP per turn. If the game needs late-game escalation, consider increasing AP to 4 after Round 15 (test separately).

Piece Freedom — Test All Four Models

Model	Rule	Rationale
A	Each piece can use at most 1 skill per turn. Moving the same piece multiple times is allowed.	Spreads skill usage. Doesn't prevent movement rushing.
B	Each piece can receive at most 1 AP per turn.	Forces spreading across army. Most restrictive — every AP goes to a different piece.
C	Uncapped normally. When ≤ 2 pieces remain, that player's pieces can receive unlimited AP.	Standard play spreads actions. Desperation mode enables comeback.
D	A single piece can receive at most 2 AP per turn. The 3rd AP must go to a different piece.	Allows Move + Skill on one piece but prevents full-AP rushing. Moderate.

Recommended test order: Start with Model D (moderate, intuitive). If too restrictive → test A. If rushing is a problem → test B. Test C as a variant on whichever base model works.

Combat

[FROM LAYERS 2–3: Use 3 HP system if accepted. Use simplified Bodyguard if accepted.]

Standard Attack: Spend 1 AP to move your piece onto an enemy-occupied tile. Deal 1 DMG. If target removed, occupy tile. If target survives, your piece stops on the tile before.

Resource Economy

[FROM LAYER 1 results.]

Skill System

Skill Path: Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

Blocking: The Skill Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

Range: The distance in tiles along the Skill Path from caster to target. Range is measured as:

- Range 0 = self (caster's own tile)
- Range 1 = adjacent tile along Skill Path
- Range 2 = 2 tiles away along Skill Path (etc.)

Default Range = 2. Unless a skill explicitly names “self” or “adjacent” in its effect text. A skill with a Range modifier (e.g. “Range –1”) is still a Range 2 skill with a modifier applied — it is not treated as adjacent or self.

Self vs. adjacent: “Self” skills (Range 0) target only the caster — they cannot target adjacent pieces, even with a Range buff. “Adjacent” skills (Range 1) target only neighbouring pieces — they cannot target the caster, even with a Range buff. Range buffs (e.g. Focus Strike) shift the targeting window outward; they do not collapse it inward.

Injured Range penalty: Injured pieces have Skill Range –1. Skills that explicitly name “self” or “adjacent” in their text are unaffected — they always work regardless of Injured status.

Skills that move pieces do not deal damage. Movement-via-skill (Quick Dash, Shadow Shift, Retreat Plan) does not count as a Standard Attack and deals no damage on arrival - you are instead stopped from moving the piece further in that direction.

A Champion may use its skills multiple times in the same turn if Skill Slots are available — including the same skill twice.

All skills cost 1 Skill Slot unless noted otherwise.

Health & Armor

All pieces have 2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed.

State	HP	Effect
Normal	2	No penalty
Injured	1	Speed capped at 1. Skill Range -1 (affects Range 2+ only).
Removed	0	Piece leaves the board permanently.

Damage:

- 1 DMG to Normal → Injured.
- 1 DMG to Injured → Removed.
- 2 DMG to Normal → Removed instantly (Injured state is skipped).

Armor: Max 3 points per piece. Each absorbs 1 DMG, then destroyed. Resolves before HP damage. **Does not prevent Injured status.**

Progression

AP per turn:

Round	AP per turn
All rounds	3
After Round 15 (optional test)	4

Skill Reference

	Cat.	Name	Cost	Effect
	Strike	Lance Thrust	2	Target within Range-1 takes 1 DMG
	Strike	Hook Pull	3	Target takes 1 DMG, pulled 1 tile toward caster along Skill Path
	Strike	Armor Breaker	2	Remove 1 Armor from target. <i>(Note: does not deal "HP-Damage" unless boosted by Blade Call)</i>
	Strike	Rune Theft	3	Target takes 1 DMG. Steal 1 Rune from opponent.
	Strike	Blade Tempest	4	Target takes 1 DMG. All pieces adjacent to the target are pushed 1 tile away from the target. The attacker/caster is not affected.
	Shield	Rust Shield	2	Self: gain +1 Armor
	Shield	Field Medic	3	Remove Injured from one adjacent ally
	Shield	Armorsmith	3	Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor
	Move	Quick Dash	3	Self: move up to 2 tiles along Skill Path
	Move	Air Blast	2	Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster
	Move	Precision Thrust	3	Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses). Range+1.
	Move	Shadow Shift	4	Swap position with an allied piece. Requires unobstructed Skill Path.
	Move	Retreat Plan	4	Self: move along Skill Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards. Range+1.
	Mystic	Focus Strike	1	The next skill used by any of your pieces this turn gains +1 Range. <i>(Note: can boost self and adjacent skills — Range 0 → 1, Range 1 → 2.)</i>
	Mystic	Blade Call	3	One Strike skill used by any of your pieces this turn deals +1 DMG.

Post-Game Questions

1. Did turns feel more fluid or more overwhelming?
2. How often did you want a 4th AP? How often did you have AP left over?
3. Did you ever rush a single piece across the board? Was it effective or punished?
4. Did "Move + Skill on the same piece" feel like a natural combo?
5. Which piece freedom model did you test? How did it feel?
6. Do you miss the two-phase structure? Or is unified AP better?
7. Should AP increase in later rounds, or is 3 flat the right number?

Layer 5: Board Size & Piece Count (Placeholder)

Cannot be fully specified until Layer 4 results are in. The AP budget and piece count interact too heavily.

Direction: Shrink to 8×8. Reduce pieces (3 Champions + 3 Guards + 1 King is the proposal, but the exact ratio depends on how AP and HP systems interact).

Key questions for Layer 5:

- Is 8×8 with 14 pieces the right density?
- Is 3:3 Champion:Guard ratio correct? (King makes 4 skill-carriers vs 3 Guards — asymmetric)
- Does starting placement matter significantly on 8×8? Should it become a strategic choice?
- Is no terrain the right call, or does the smaller board need terrain to create interesting zones?

Will be written as a full rule sheet after Layers 1–4 are resolved.